

Chapter 10 — Multi-step Workflows

12 workflows

Everything so far does one job. This chapter chains them: the output of step one becomes the input to step two, and by the end you have a finished piece of work rather than a pile of drafts.

WHAT'S IN HERE

ID	WORKFLOW	YOU END UP WITH
WF-001	Standard to complete unit	A sequenced unit with checkpoints
WF-002	Mixed-ability lesson pack	One lesson, three routes, one discussion
WF-003	Incident to parent conversation	A documented, careful conversation
WF-004	Scores to report comments	A whole class of comments, traced to evidence
WF-005	Standard to aligned assessment	A paper with a blueprint and a checked key
WF-006	Emergency substitute pack	A day another adult can teach
WF-007	Project launch pack	Brief, milestones and rubric that agree
WF-008	Parent conference pack	Cards for a whole evening of conferences
WF-009	Evidence to intervention-plan draft	A draft to take to your school's process
WF-010	Field-trip planning pack	A plan with its gaps named
WF-011	Weekly teacher admin pack	A week of paperwork cleared
WF-012	Class data reflection	What the data supports, and what it does not

HOW TO RUN THESE

Keep each workflow in one conversation. Steps say things like "using the unit plan above" — that only works if the plan is above. Do not start a fresh chat between steps.

Read each step's output before running the next one. An error in step one becomes the foundation of steps two through six. This is the one place in the book where skipping the check is genuinely expensive.

If a step asks you something, answer it. Pushing on with a gap makes every later step guess.

Stop between steps whenever you want. A workflow is a suggested route, not a contract. Several of these end by telling you what they could not do — that is the workflow working, not failing.

WF-001 Standard to complete unit

Replaces roughly 3-4 hours

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

A standard, a number of lessons, and nothing in between.

COPY THIS PROMPT

We are going to build a unit together, one step at a time. Do only the step I ask for, then stop and wait. Do not run ahead.

Context for all steps:

- Grade and subject: [GRADE] [SUBJECT]
- Standard, exact wording: [PASTE IT]
- Number of lessons: [NUMBER]
- Already taught: [PRIOR LEARNING]
- Constraints: [TIME, MATERIALS, ANYTHING ELSE]

STEP 1 – Unpack the standard.

Break it into 4-6 things students must be able to do, each teachable and checkable in one lesson. Use only my wording; do not add requirements from other versions of this standard. Say what part of the standard your list does not cover.

Then stop. I will read it and confirm before you continue.

THEN, ONE AT A TIME

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 2 – Design the final assessment.

Using the components from Step 1, design what students do at the end to show they have met the standard. Give me the task, what a strong response contains, and what a response looks like when the knowledge is there but the skill is not.

Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 3 – Sequence the lessons.

Working backward from the Step 2 assessment, sequence the [NUMBER] lessons. One line per lesson on what it does and why it sits there. Mark which lessons are load-bearing and which could be cut if we lose time. Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 4 – Place the checkpoints.

Add a checkpoint roughly every third lesson. For each: the actual question, what a poor result would look like, and the specific reteach for the next lesson. No pass percentages. Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 5 – Review the whole thing.

Audit what we have built: gaps, repetition, whether demand rises, and the two lessons most likely to go wrong. Be blunt. Tell me what you would change.

BEFORE YOU USE IT

- Check the Step 1 unpacking against the standard's real wording before Step 2.
- If Step 5 finds a real problem, go back rather than teaching around it.

WF-002 Mixed-ability lesson pack

Replaces roughly 2 hours

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

One lesson that works for a class with a wide spread.

COPY THIS PROMPT

We are building a differentiated lesson in steps. Do one step at a time and stop after each.

Context:

- Grade and subject: [GRADE] [SUBJECT]
- Objective: [OBJECTIVE]
- Lesson length: [MINUTES]. Class size: [NUMBER]
- The spread, described as needs not students: [DESCRIBE]
- Materials: [LIST]

STEP 1 – Build the core lesson.

Plan the on-level lesson: opening, modelling, guided practice, independent work, exit ticket. Build it backward from what would show the objective was met. Then stop.

THEN, ONE AT A TIME

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 2 – Add the two other routes.

From the Step 1 lesson, create a scaffolded route and an extension route. Same thinking, same materials, same finishing time. The extension must be harder thinking, not more items. Name the routes neutrally, in no order that reads as a ranking. Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 3 – Write the shared check.

One check every student completes, regardless of route, from which I cannot tell which route they took. Give me what each level of response looks like. Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 4 – Plan the closing discussion.

A discussion that works for all three routes without anyone announcing which they did. An opening question everyone can answer, the order I take contributions, and the shared conclusion. Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 5 – Check the dignity.

Review all three routes. Would the class work out which is the lesser one?

Does

every route have something worth sharing? Tell me the single change that would most equalise them.

BEFORE YOU USE IT

- Answer Step 5 honestly yourself before teaching it.
- Could you tell from the shared check which route a student took?

WF-003 Incident to parent conversation

Replaces roughly 1 hour, and a lot of worrying

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Something happened, and the conversation has to be right.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Help me prepare a family conversation, one step at a time. Stop after each step.

Before we start: if what I describe involves harm, abuse, or immediate danger, stop and tell me to follow my school's safeguarding process instead of continuing this workflow.

Context:

- Grade: [GRADE]
- What happened, observably, with dates: [DESCRIBE. No student names.]
- What I have already done: [LIST IT]
- What I want from the conversation: [STATE IT]

STEP 1 – Separate fact from interpretation.

Go through what I wrote. List what I observed, and separately what I have concluded or assumed. Flag anything I have written as fact that is actually inference. Then stop.

THEN, ONE AT A TIME

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 2 – Build the factual account.

Using only the observed facts from Step 1, write the account I would give the family: what happened, when, what I did. No character description, no cause, no speculation about home. Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 3 – Prepare the conversation.

My opening under 30 seconds, the facts in the order I say them, and what I say when the family disagrees, becomes upset, or says it is the school's responsibility. Include the point where I stop and listen. Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 4 – Write the follow-up.

A summary email recording what was discussed and agreed, with owners and dates.

Record disagreement as disagreement. Invite correction. Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 5 – Check it.

Review everything: any claim I cannot evidence, anywhere a family could reasonably read blame, anything that belongs in a safeguarding process rather than a conversation with me. Tell me the one sentence to cut.

BEFORE YOU USE IT

- If Step 1 flags inference as fact, fix it before Step 2.
- If any step raises safeguarding, stop and use your school's process.

WF-004 Scores to report comments

Replaces roughly 3 hours

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Report season, a whole class, one sitting.

COPY THIS PROMPT

We are drafting report comments in steps. Stop after each step.

Context:

- Grade and subject: [GRADE] [SUBJECT]
- Character limit: [NUMBER, or none]
- Evidence table: [PASTE IT. Use initials or Student A, B, C. No full names.]

STEP 1 – Check my evidence.

Look at my table. Tell me which rows have enough to write a meaningful comment,

which are thin, and which are so thin that I should write a shorter comment rather than a padded one. Do not draft anything yet. Then stop.

THEN, ONE AT A TIME

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 2 – Build the comment structure.

A structure: strength with evidence, then one next step. Give me 6 openings and

6 closings I can rotate so thirty comments do not read as one. Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 3 – Draft the comments.

Draft one comment per row. Every clause must come from that student's own row. Never carry a detail, phrase or achievement from one row into another. For a thin row, write shorter – do not borrow to fill it. Mark any clause you could not source. Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 4 – Check for leakage.

Go back over the drafts against the table. Report separately: any detail appearing in the wrong student's comment, any two comments similar enough that a family comparing them would notice, any claim not in the table. Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 5 – Final pass.

Check every comment for: unfilled placeholders, fixed-ability language, comment

on effort or personality rather than learning, promises about future performance, and repeated openings. List what needs my attention.

BEFORE YOU USE IT

error that does real damage.

- Verify Step 4's leakage findings against your table yourself. This is the
- Fill every placeholder before submitting.

WF-005 Standard to aligned assessment

Replaces roughly 2-3 hours

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

A paper that tests what you taught, with a key you can trust.

COPY THIS PROMPT

We are building an assessment in steps. Stop after each.

Context:

- Grade and subject: [GRADE] [SUBJECT]
- Objectives or standard, exact wording: [PASTE THEM]
- Time available: [MINUTES]. Total marks: [NUMBER]
- What was actually taught: [LIST IT]

STEP 1 – Build the blueprint.

A table: each objective, marks allocated with a reason, the type of question that suits it, and how many questions. Say which objectives cannot be assessed in writing and should be assessed another way. Do not write questions yet. Then stop.

THEN, ONE AT A TIME

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 2 – Write the questions.

Using the blueprint, write the paper. Marks shown per question. For any multiple choice, every wrong option must be a real misconception you can name. Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 3 – Write the key.

A full worked key: answers, working, the most likely wrong answer for each and where it comes from. Check every calculation and show it. Flag anything you cannot verify independently rather than presenting it as checked. Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 4 – Audit the paper.

Against the blueprint: does each question test what it should, is any wording ambiguous, is the reading demand higher than the subject demand, and does any question allow a second defensible answer? Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 5 – Time it.

Estimate honestly how long a middling student needs, question by question.

Compare with the time I have. Tell me what to cut if it does not fit, and what evidence I lose by cutting it.

BEFORE YOU USE IT

- Work the entire key yourself. Step 3 flags what it doubts; check the rest too.
- Take Step 5's timing seriously. Papers always run long.

WF-006 Emergency substitute pack

Replaces roughly 90 minutes, usually at 6am

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

You are ill, and someone else has your classes today.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Build me a substitute pack in steps. Stop after each. Keep it fast – I am writing this while unwell.

Context:

- Grade and subject: [GRADE] [SUBJECT]
- Periods to cover: [NUMBER], each [MINUTES]
- Where the class is up to: [TOPIC]
- What is in the room: [MATERIALS. Say if nothing can be printed.]

STEP 1 – Choose the work.

Propose work that is meaningful, needs no subject knowledge from the substitute, requires no preparation, and does not depend on knowing the class. Tell me why each choice survives a stranger teaching it. Then stop.

THEN, ONE AT A TIME

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 2 – Write the student task.

Write it out in full, ready to photocopy or dictate, with everything students need on the page. Include the answer key. Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 3 – Write the substitute directions.

Minute by minute. Exactly what goes on the board. What to say. What to do when students say we have done this, when someone finishes early, and when someone refuses. No step requiring subject knowledge. Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 4 – Write the class note.

Three lines on what this class is like and what to watch for, without describing any individual student. Plus what to leave me a note about, and where work gets collected. Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 5 – Check it.

Read the whole pack as someone who has never taught this subject and never met this class. Tell me every point where they would have to guess.

BEFORE YOU USE IT

- Fix every guess-point Step 5 finds. That is the whole value of this pack.
- Check the answer key, even at 6am.

WF-007 Project launch pack

Replaces roughly 3 hours

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

A project where the brief, the milestones and the rubric actually agree.

COPY THIS PROMPT

We are building a project pack in steps. Stop after each.

Context:

- Grade and subject: [GRADE] [SUBJECT]
- Objective: [WHAT STUDENTS SHOULD BE ABLE TO DO]
- Duration: [WEEKS OR LESSONS]
- Constraints: [CLASS SIZE, RESOURCES, WHETHER GROUPS]

STEP 1 – Define the outcome.

The driving question and the final product. The question must be open enough to sustain the work and narrow enough to finish. Be honest about scope: if the duration is not enough for this product, say so and propose one that fits. Then stop.

THEN, ONE AT A TIME

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 2 – Write the student brief.

One page, written for students. What they are making, why, what it must contain with the learning listed first, what is up to them, and the three questions students will ask on day one, answered in advance. Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 3 – Build the milestones.

One per week, each producing something I can look at in under two minutes per student or group. What on track and behind look like at each, and the specific intervention for behind. Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 4 – Write the rubric.

Criteria drawn from the objective, not from the format. Most weight on thinking and subject learning; presentation as one small criterion. Nothing rewarding resources a student may not have at home. Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 5 – Check the three agree.

Compare the brief, the milestones and the rubric. Does the rubric reward what the brief asks for? Do the milestones lead to it? Could a student follow the brief exactly and still score badly? Tell me every mismatch.

BEFORE YOU USE IT

- Step 5 is the point of this workflow. Fix every mismatch before handing it out.
- Could a beautiful project with weak thinking score well? Fix the rubric if so.

WF-008 Parent conference pack

Replaces roughly 2-3 hours

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Twenty-four families in one evening, ten minutes each.

COPY THIS PROMPT

We are preparing conference cards in steps. Stop after each.

Context:

- Grade and subject: [GRADE] [SUBJECT]
- Minutes per family: [NUMBER]
- My notes: [PASTE THEM. Initials or Student A. No full names.]

STEP 1 – Sort my notes.

For each student, tell me what my notes support saying, and where they are too thin. Flag anywhere I have written an impression as though it were evidence. Do not draft cards yet. Then stop.

THEN, ONE AT A TIME

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 2 – Build the card format.

Half a page I can scan while a family sits down: one strength with evidence, one growth area with evidence, one open question for the family, one thing they could do at home in under ten minutes needing no subject knowledge, and my opening and closing sentences. Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 3 – Fill the cards.

One card per student, using only that student's notes. Never carry a detail between students. Where my notes are thin, write a shorter card and say what I should observe before the conference. Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 4 – Prepare for the hard ones.

From my notes, identify which conversations are likely to be difficult. For each: my opening, what I say if the family disagrees, and the point where I say this needs a longer separate meeting. Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 5 – Check the cards.

Any claim I cannot evidence, any suggestion assuming a family has money, internet, time, or subject knowledge, and any card that reads as a verdict rather than a conversation.

BEFORE YOU USE IT

- Fix anything Step 1 flags as impression before it reaches a card.
- Practise the Step 4 openings aloud once.

WF-009 Evidence to intervention-plan draft

Replaces roughly 2 hours

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Preparing a draft to take into your school's process — not to act on alone.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Help me draft an intervention plan in steps. Stop after each.

Read this first: this is a draft to take into my school's own process. It is not a decision, a diagnosis, or a referral. If at any step the evidence points toward something requiring a specialist, a safeguarding response, or a formal assessment, say so and tell me to stop and use my school's process instead of continuing.

Context:

- Grade and subject: [GRADE] [SUBJECT]
- What I observe, with dates and frequency: [DESCRIBE. No names.]
- What I have already tried, and what happened: [LIST IT]
- What my school's process expects at this stage: [DESCRIBE IT, or say unknown]

STEP 1 – Sort the evidence.

Separate what I have observed from what I have concluded. Give me three possible explanations consistent with the observations, and what would distinguish them. Name no cause. Then stop.

THEN, ONE AT A TIME

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 2 – Identify what I do not know.

List what I would need to observe or check to tell those explanations apart, and the quickest classroom way to find each out. Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 3 – Draft the classroom actions.

Specific things I do in the classroom, each small enough to sustain. For each: what I do, how often, and what I record. Nothing requiring resources or staffing

I have not mentioned. Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 4 – Set the review.

What I look at, when, and the three outcomes: working, partly working, not working. For each, the decision – including escalating to my school's process, which is a legitimate outcome and not a failure. Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 5 – Check the draft.

Anywhere I have named a cause I cannot know, anywhere this reaches beyond what a class teacher should decide alone, and anything that belongs in my school's formal process now rather than after a review cycle.

BEFORE YOU USE IT

- Take this draft to your school's process. It is not a plan you own alone.
- If any step says stop and escalate, do that.

WF-010 Field-trip planning pack

Replaces roughly 2 hours

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

A trip plan with its gaps named rather than filled in.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Build a trip planning pack in steps. Stop after each.

Read this first: do not state any ratio, form, timescale, insurance requirement or policy I have not given you. Where a standard requirement is missing from what I supply, write [CHECK WITH SCHOOL] rather than filling it in.

I will verify everything against my school's own procedures.

Context:

- Destination and activity: [DESCRIBE]
- Date, year group, number of students: [STATE THEM]
- Adults available: [NUMBER AND ROLES]
- My school's requirements as I understand them: [PASTE OR SUMMARISE]

STEP 1 – Build the backwards checklist.

Working back from the trip date: approvals, consent, transport, staffing, medical and dietary information, money, communication. Mark every item I did not supply as [CHECK WITH SCHOOL]. Then stop.

THEN, ONE AT A TIME

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 2 – Check accessibility.

Go through the activity and the day. Anything assuming a student can walk far, climb, tolerate noise or crowds, eat a standard meal, or afford a cost. List these separately – a trip a student cannot join is a problem to solve before booking. Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 3 – Build the day schedule.

One page for every adult: each time slot, the responsible adult by name, head count points with boxes to write the number and time, and blank fields for contacts and the meeting point. Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 4 – Plan the contingencies.

Late coach, bad weather, a student unwell, a student separated from the group, a return after the school day ends. Who is told, in what order. Mark anything that depends on school procedure as [CHECK WITH SCHOOL]. Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 5 – List the unknowns.

Everything in this pack I have written as settled that is actually assumed, and everything still marked [CHECK WITH SCHOOL], as one list I can take to whoever approves trips.

BEFORE YOU USE IT

- Step 5's list is what you take to the approver. Do not shorten it.
- Solve the accessibility gaps before booking.

WF-011 Weekly teacher admin pack

Replaces roughly 90 minutes

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

Friday afternoon, and the paperwork has stacked up.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Help me clear this week's admin in steps. Stop after each.

Here is everything, unsorted: [DUMP YOUR NOTES, EMAILS TO WRITE, MEETING NOTES, DEADLINES, THINGS YOU PROMISED SOMEONE. No student names.]

STEP 1 – Sort it.

Into four piles: needs an email, needs a decision from me, needs someone else, and can be dropped. For the drop pile, say why each can go. Tell me which item is most overdue and which has the largest consequence if missed – they are often not the same. Then stop.

THEN, ONE AT A TIME

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 2 – Draft the emails.

For each item needing an email: the ask in the first line, under 120 words, one action each, with a subject line naming the action and deadline. Use only facts from my notes; mark anything I need to verify. Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 3 – Turn the meeting notes into minutes.

Decisions, actions with owners and dates, and open items. Write [OWNER?] or [DATE?] where my notes do not say – do not assign either yourself. Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 4 – Build next week's list.

What is genuinely due next week, ordered by deadline. Separately, what I have carried for more than two weeks – those need deciding or dropping, not carrying again. Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 5 – Tell me what I am avoiding.

From everything I dumped, which item have I clearly been putting off, and what is the smallest first step on it.

BEFORE YOU USE IT

- Fill every [OWNER?] and [DATE?] before circulating minutes.
- Step 5 is usually right. Do the smallest step today.

WF-012 Class data reflection

Replaces roughly 90 minutes

WHEN YOU NEED THIS

A set of results, and a decision to make about what to do next.

COPY THIS PROMPT

Help me read this class data in steps. Stop after each.

Context:

- Grade and subject: [GRADE] [SUBJECT]
- What the assessment covered: [DESCRIBE]
- The data: [PASTE IT – no student names]
- What I taught, and how: [DESCRIBE BRIEFLY]

STEP 1 – Describe what is there.

Only what the data shows. Patterns, spread, which items were missed most. No explanations yet, no conclusions about students. If the data is too thin to support a pattern, say so. Then stop.

THEN, ONE AT A TIME

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 2 – Explain it, several ways.

For each main pattern, give me three possible explanations – including ones that are not about my teaching, and ones about the assessment itself rather than the learning. Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 3 – Test the explanations.

For each, what evidence would confirm or rule it out, and how I would get that in a normal week. Tell me which explanation I am most likely to reach for without checking. Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 4 – Decide the action.

Based on what the data actually supports: what I reteach, what I move on from, and what I gather more evidence on before deciding. For each, why. Then stop.

COPY THIS PROMPT

STEP 5 – Say what this cannot tell me.
What I would be over-reading if I drew it from this data, and what I should not
conclude about any individual student from a single assessment.

BEFORE YOU USE IT

- Step 3 names your own bias. Sit with that one.
- Step 5 matters most. Do not carry an over-reading into a report comment.